

Marathon Training Plan - 3:50 Goal - Oct 18 2026

16-Week Marathon Training Plan with Strength & Nutrition

4 days running/week (Tue, Thu, Sat long run, Sun easy) + 2 days strength training. Goal: finish strong, hit 3:50, and lose 10-15 lbs safely.

Race Day: Sunday, October 18, 2026 Training Block Starts: Monday, June 29, 2026

Target Race Time: 3:50:00

Pace Zone	Target Pace (min/mile)	Target Pace (min/km)	Used For
Marathon Pace (MP)	8:46/mi	5:27/km	Race day; back-half segments of key long runs (weeks 11+)
Tempo/ Threshold Pace (TP)	8:00-8:15/mi	4:58-5:08/km	Tuesday tempo/ threshold workouts
Easy Pace (EP)	9:45-10:15/mi	6:03-6:22/km	All easy/ recovery runs, warm-ups, cooldowns
Speed/ Interval Pace	~7:30-7:40/mi (800m-1mi repeats)	~4:40-4:45/ km	Shorter speed reps, used sparingly

These are estimates based on a 3:50 marathon goal (using standard race-pace equivalency charts) and assume reasonably even pacing. **Recalibrate after a tune-up race** — aim for a 10K or half marathon around **Aug 24-31 (week 9-10)** — plug your actual result into a pace calculator to refine these numbers before your peak weeks (Sept 21 onward).

How to Use This Plan

- **Running days:** Tuesday (speed/tempo), Thursday (easy/moderate), Saturday (long run), Sunday (recovery run or rest)
- **Strength days:** Monday and Wednesday (or Friday), 30-40 min sessions
- **Rest/cross-train:** Friday (light yoga, walk, or full rest)
- Use the pace table above for every workout below — EP, TP, and MP refer back to those numbers.
- **Listen to your body.** If you feel pain (not just fatigue), take an extra rest day. Adjust mileage down 10-20% if needed — consistency beats heroics.

Training Plan Overview (16 Weeks)

Week	Week Of	Tue (Speed/ Tempo)	Thu (Easy/ Moderate)	Sat (Long Run)	Sun (Recovery)	Weekly Mileage (approx)
1	Jun 29	3 mi easy + 4x100m strides	3 mi easy	6 mi LR	2 mi recovery	~14
2	Jul 6	4 mi w/ 3x800m @ TP	3 mi easy	7 mi LR	2 mi recovery	~16
3	Jul 13	4 mi w/ 4x800m @ TP	4 mi easy	8 mi LR	3 mi recovery	~19
4	Jul 20	3 mi easy (cutback)	3 mi easy	6 mi LR (cutback)	2 mi recovery	~14
5	Jul 27	5 mi w/ 20 min tempo	4 mi easy	10 mi LR	3 mi recovery	~22
6	Aug 3	5 mi w/ 5x600m @ TP	4 mi easy	11 mi LR	3 mi recovery	~23
7			5 mi easy	12 mi LR		~26

Week	Week Of	Tue (Speed/ Tempo)	Thu (Easy/ Moderate)	Sat (Long Run)	Sun (Recovery)	Weekly Mileage (approx)
	Aug 10	6 mi w/ 25 min tempo			3 mi recovery	
8	Aug 17	4 mi easy (cutback)	4 mi easy	8 mi LR (cutback)	2 mi recovery	~18
9	Aug 24	6 mi w/ 4x1mi @ TP	5 mi easy	14 mi LR	4 mi recovery	~29
10	Aug 31	6 mi w/ 30 min tempo	5 mi easy	15 mi LR	4 mi recovery	~30
11	Sep 7	6 mi w/ 5x1mi @ TP	5 mi easy	16 mi LR (incl. 4 mi @ MP)	4 mi recovery	~31
12	Sep 14	5 mi easy (cutback)	4 mi easy	10 mi LR (cutback)	3 mi recovery	~22
13	Sep 21	6 mi w/ 6x1mi @ TP	5 mi easy	18 mi LR (incl. 6 mi @ MP)	4 mi recovery	~33 (Peak Week)
14	Sep 28	5 mi w/ 20 min tempo	4 mi easy	13 mi LR (incl. 4 mi @ MP)	3 mi recovery	~25 (taper begins)
15	Oct 5	4 mi easy w/ strides	3 mi easy	8 mi LR easy	2 mi recovery	~17 (taper)
16	Oct 12	3 mi easy w/ strides	2 mi easy	Rest/3 mi shakeout (Fri, Oct 16)	RACE DAY — Sun, Oct 18	~8 + race

Notes: - Cutback weeks (4, 8, 12) reduce volume ~25% to absorb training stress — don't skip these. - "TP" (Tempo Pace) = 8:00-8:15/mi (see pace table above), roughly comfortably hard — "could hold a short conversation but wouldn't want to." - "MP" (Marathon Pace) = 8:46/mi, your 3:50 target pace, practiced in the back half of key long runs from week 11 onward. - Race week: shakeout run Friday is optional, very short and easy, just to keep legs loose.

Strength Training Plan (2x/week — Monday & Wednesday)

Goal: build running-specific strength (glutes, core, hips, calves) to improve economy and reduce injury risk, without excess soreness that hurts running days. Keep weights moderate, focus on form and control. 30-40 minutes per session.

Day A — Lower Body & Core (Monday)

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Notes
Goblet Squats	3 x 10-12	Moderate dumbbell/kettlebell
Romanian Deadlifts	3 x 10	Light-moderate barbell or dumbbells
Walking Lunges	3 x 10/leg	Bodyweight or light dumbbells
Single-Leg Glute Bridge	3 x 12/leg	Bodyweight
Calf Raises (single leg)	3 x 15/leg	Add weight as it gets easy
Plank	3 x 45-60 sec	
Side Plank	2 x 30 sec/side	

Day B — Upper Body, Hips & Stability (Wednesday)

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Notes
Push-ups	3 x 10-15	Modify on knees if needed
Dumbbell Rows	3 x 10/arm	
Lateral Band Walks	3 x 15 steps/side	Mini-band, key for hip stability/injury prevention
Clamshells	3 x 15/side	
Step-ups (onto bench/box)	3 x 10/leg	
Dead Bug	3 x 10/side	Core/anti-rotation
Bird Dog	3 x 10/side	

Progression: Increase reps or weight every 2 weeks if exercises feel manageable. Drop to one strength session/week during weeks 13-16 (peak/taper) to protect recovery for key long runs.

Nutrition Plan for Sustainable Fat Loss (10-15 lbs) During Marathon Training

Losing weight while training for a marathon is a balancing act: too aggressive a deficit impairs recovery, increases injury risk, and hurts performance. This plan targets a **modest, sustainable deficit (~300-500 calories/day)**, which combined with marathon training's calorie burn should produce roughly **0.5-1 lb/week loss** — landing you in the 10-15 lb range over the 16-week block, give or take.

General Principles

- **Don't under-fuel long runs or race day** — this is non-negotiable. Deficit comes from rest-day and easy-day eating, not from skimping around hard workouts.
- **Protein first:** aim for roughly 0.7-1g of protein per lb of bodyweight daily to preserve muscle while losing fat.
- **Carbs scale with training load:** more carbs on long run/tempo days, fewer on rest days.
- **Hydrate consistently:** aim for pale-yellow urine; add electrolytes on long run days (especially in heat).
- **Don't fear food before/after key runs** — under-fueling here is the #1 cause of stalled weight loss + bad workouts (you compensate by overeating later or feeling too fatigued to train well).

Daily Structure (example — adjust portions to your size/activity)

Easy/Rest Days (lower carb need): | Meal | Example | |—|—| |
Breakfast | Greek yogurt, berries, handful of nuts, drizzle of honey |
| | Lunch | Large salad with grilled chicken or chickpeas, olive oil vinaigrette, whole-grain roll | | Snack | Apple + 1 tbsp peanut butter | | Dinner | Baked salmon or tofu, roasted vegetables, small portion quinoa or rice | | Evening (if hungry) | Cottage cheese or a small handful of almonds |

Hard Workout / Long Run Days (higher carb need): | Meal | Example | |—|—| | Pre-run (1-2 hrs before) | Oatmeal with banana and a little honey, or toast with jam | | During long runs (>75-90 min) | Sports drink, gel, or chews every 30-45 min (~30-60g carbs/hr) | | Post-run (within 30-60 min) | Recovery shake or chocolate milk + banana — protein + carbs | | Lunch | Turkey or

bean wrap, brown rice, vegetables | | Dinner | Pasta or rice bowl with lean protein (chicken, fish, tofu) and lots of vegetables | | Snacks | Fruit, yogurt, trail mix |

Sample Weekly Calorie/Macro Targets (*adjust to your size — these are illustrative*)

- **Rest/Easy days:** ~80–90% of maintenance calories; protein 30%, carbs 35–40%, fat 25–30%
- **Long run/hard days:** at or slightly above maintenance; protein 20–25%, carbs 50–55%, fat 20–25%

Foods to Emphasize

- Lean proteins: chicken, fish, eggs, Greek yogurt, tofu, legumes
- Complex carbs: oats, brown rice, quinoa, sweet potatoes, whole grain bread/pasta
- Healthy fats: olive oil, avocado, nuts, seeds (in moderation — calorie dense)
- Plenty of vegetables and fruit for micronutrients and fiber/satiety
- Electrolyte-rich foods/drinks on long run days (bananas, electrolyte tabs, salty snacks)

Foods to Limit (Not Eliminate)

- Sugary drinks and excess alcohol (empty calories, hurt recovery)
- Fried/highly processed foods on a regular basis
- Very large portions of refined carbs on non-training days

Practical Tips

- Weigh yourself 1–2x/week, same time of day, and track the **trend** not daily fluctuation.
 - If weight loss stalls for 2+ weeks despite consistent habits, reduce daily intake by another ~150–200 calories.
 - If you're constantly fatigued, sleeping poorly, or workouts feel terrible — you're likely under-fueling. Eat more, especially carbs around training.
 - Prioritize sleep (7–9 hrs) — it affects both recovery and appetite regulation as much as diet does.
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Race Week Checklist

- Carb-load lightly days 2–3 before race (no need for “carb loading” excess — just don't under-eat carbs)

- Hydrate well all week, especially with electrolytes
- Lay out gear, bib, fuel the night before
- Eat a familiar, carb-forward breakfast 2-3 hrs before race start
- Trust the training — you've earned this.

This plan is for general guidance and isn't a substitute for advice from a doctor, registered dietitian, or running coach — especially if you have any existing injuries, health conditions, or significant weight-loss goals beyond this range.